Quiplash: The Definitive Reference Document

Quiplash is the flagship joke-writing battle game developed by Jackbox Games. Originally funded via a Kickstarter campaign and released as a standalone title on June 30, 2015, before headlining The Jackbox Party Pack 2 as *Quiplash XL*, it established the core blueprint for modern mobile-controlled party games. Unlike card-based humor games (Cards Against Humanity or Apples to Apples) that rely on pre-printed punchlines, Quiplash provides only the setup—forcing players to write their own punchlines under time pressure and pit them head-to-head for the room's votes.

1. Production & Technical Architecture

- **Core Creative Team:**
  - **Game Director & Editorial Lead:** Steve Heinrich
  - **Host:** Josh "Schmitty" Schmitstinstein, voiced by veteran Jellyvision/Jackbox writer and audio engineer **Phil Ridarelli** (Schmitty first debuted in *You Don't Know Jack: 5th Dementia* in 2000).
  - **Lead Programmer:** Ben Jacobs
  - **Music & Audio Director:** Andy Poland
  - **Art Direction:** Dave Innis (*Quiplash 1* & *2* 2D vector style); reworked into a 3D stop-motion/claymation aesthetic for *Quiplash 3*.
- **Client-Server Topology:**
  - **Host Screen (Primary Display):** Runs locally on PC, console, smart TV, or cloud stream, rendering prompts, animations, voiceovers, and live vote tallies.
  - **Controller Client (`jackbox.tv`):** Players connect via any mobile or desktop web browser using a 4-letter Room Code (or by scanning an on-screen QR code in newer releases like *The Jackbox Party Essentials*).
- **Player & Audience Capacity:**
  - **Active Players: 3 to 8 players**. (The VIP—the first player to join—controls game start and post-game replay prompts).
  - **Audience Members:** Up to **10,000 spectators** can join using the same Room Code once the 8 player slots fill (or at any point mid-game). Audience votes are aggregated as a percentage and directly impact player scoring and bonus thresholds.

2. How It Works: Core Gameplay Loop

A standard game of *Quiplash* takes approximately **15 minutes** and is structured into **three rounds**: two head-to-head rounds followed by a high-stakes finale.

The Circular Prompt-Pairing Topology (Rounds 1 & 2)

At the beginning of Rounds 1 and 2, the game generates a mathematical ring topology among all N active players:

1. Every player receives **two distinct prompts** sequentially on their mobile device.
2. Each prompt is secretly shared with **one other player** in the lobby.
3. To prevent constant rematches within the same round, the server assigns pairings around a virtual circle (Player 1 faces Player 2 on Prompt A, and faces Player N on Prompt B). Consequently, in an N-player game, there are exactly N head-to-head matchups per round.
4. Players have a set timer (typically **75 to 90 seconds total** for both prompts, extendable in settings) to submit text responses ("quips") up to **45 characters** in length.

The Voting & Reveal Phase

Once all quips are submitted (or the timer expires), the game moves to the showroom floor:

1. Schmitty reads one prompt aloud and displays both anonymous player responses side-by-side on the main screen.
2. **Who Votes:** All active players *except* the two authors of the current matchup must vote on their favorite answer within **15 seconds**, alongside all connected Audience members.
3. **Anonymity:** Author identities are hidden during voting so players judge purely on humor (or inside-joke recognition) rather than targeting specific scoreboard leaders.
4. **The Reveal:** Once votes lock in, the authors' names appear under their quips, individual player icons pop up above the quip they voted for, the Audience percentage bar fills, and points are awarded.

3. Complete Scoring Mathematics & Mechanics

Points in *Quiplash* are calculated using a percentage distribution of a fixed base point pool per matchup, plus conditional sweep bonuses.

Round-by-Round Point Values

Mechanic / Event	Round 1 Value	Round 2 Value (Doubled)	Round 3 (The Last Lash - Q1/XL/Q2)	Round 3 (Thriplash - Q3)
Base Matchup Point Pool	**1,000 pts**	**2,000 pts**	**3,000 pts (shared across all...**	**3,000 pts** (head-to-head base pool)
Point Formula per 1% of Votes	**10 pts** per 1%	**20 pts** per 1%	**30 pts per 1%**	**30 pts** per 1% (up to **6,000 pts** max total)
Standard Winner Bonus	**+100 pts**	**+200 pts**	N/A (proportional distributio...	Included in multiplier scaling

Mechanic / Event	Round 1 Value	Round 2 Value (Doubled)	Round 3 (The Last Lash - Q1/XL/Q2)	Round 3 (Thriplash - Q3)
Quiplash Bonus (Sweep)	**+250 pts** (replaces +100)	**+500 pts** (replaces +200)	N/A	**+750 pts** (up to **+1,500 pts** with Super/bonuses)
Super Quiplash Bonus	**+250 pts** + fanfare (or +350 in XL/2)	**+500 pts** + fanfare	N/A	**Up to 6,000 pts total cap**

Special Scoring Conditions & Edge Cases

- **Standard Win vs. Tie:**
  - Every eligible player vote and the collective Audience vote are weighted into a combined percentage (0% to 100%).
  - *Example (Round 1):* If Player A receives 75% of the vote and Player B receives 25%, Player A earns 750 (base) + 100 (Winner Bonus) = 850 pts, while Player B earns 250 pts.
  - If both players receive exactly **50%** of the vote, they split the base pool evenly (500 pts each in Round 1; 1,000 pts each in Round 2) and **neither player receives the Winner Bonus**.
- **Quiplash (The Sweep):**
  - Triggered when a player receives **100% of the active player votes** (requires a game of **5 or more players**, meaning at least 3 eligible player voters) AND **more than 50% of the Audience vote** (if an Audience is present).
  - Instead of the standard +100/+200 Winner Bonus, the winner gets the **Quiplash Bonus** (+250 in Round 1, +500 in Round 2), bringing a Round 1 100%-vote sweep to **1,250 points** and a Round 2 sweep to **2,500 points**.
- **Super Quiplash:**
  - Triggered when a player achieves a standard Quiplash (100% of player votes) AND captures **more than 90% of the Audience vote**.
- **JINX! (Duplicate Answers):**
  - If both opponents submit the **exact same text string** (ignoring capitalization and minor punctuation/articles like "a" or "the"), a loud alarm triggers and the matchup is declared a **JINX!**.
  - Voting is skipped entirely, and **both players receive 0 points**.
- **Safety Quips ("Write For Me"):**
  - Introduced in *Quiplash 2*, players who are stuck can press the **Safety Quip** button on their controller to have the game auto-fill a pre-written gag answer.
  - In *Quiplash 2*, Safety Quips were completely random, context-blind phrases (e.g., *"gluten-free cannibalism"* or *"a sad fat dragon with no friends"*). In *Quiplash 3*, Safety Quips were upgraded to be contextually tied to the specific prompt.

    - **The Penalty:** If a Safety Quip wins or earns votes, the game publicly exposes that the player used a Safety Quip after voting concludes, and **all points earned from that prompt are cut in half (50%)**. Safety Quips are disabled in Round 3.
- **Forfeits, Timeouts & Censorship:**
    - If a player fails to submit an answer before the timer runs out, or if their answer is blocked by a live moderator, no voting occurs. The opponent wins by default and automatically receives **100% of the base points (1,000 in Round 1; 2,000 in Round 2)**, though without a Quiplash sweep bonus.
    - If *both* players fail to answer the same prompt, neither earns points.

4. Final Round Variants Across Editions

Round 3 changes the structure dramatically depending on which edition of *Quiplash* you are playing.

A. *Quiplash* & *Quiplash XL*: Classic *The Last Lash*

- **How It Works:** All players receive the **exact same single prompt**.
- **Voting:** Every player's response is displayed on screen simultaneously. Each player gets **three votes** (or weighted medals depending on player count) to distribute among their favorite answers (you cannot vote for your own).
- **Scoring:** A single **3,000-point pool** is divided across all players strictly by the percentage of total votes received (1% = 30 pts), revealed in ascending order from fewest votes to most votes.

B. *Quiplash 2*: Revamped *The Last Lash* (3 Random Modes)

Instead of a standard text prompt, *Quiplash 2* randomly selects one of three specialized creative challenges that every player answers simultaneously:

1. **Acro Lash:** Players are given a random 3-letter acronym (e.g., `F.B.I.` or `W.T.F.`) and must invent what the letters stand for.
2. **Word Lash:** Players are given a root word or phrase with a blank (e.g., `"The worst new reality show: Storage ______"`) or asked to coin a definition/use for a word.
3. **Comic Lash:** Players are shown a single-panel cartoon drawing with an empty speech or thought bubble and must write the caption/dialogue.

- **Medal Voting:** In games with 5 to 8 players, each voter awards a **Gold Medal**, **Silver Medal**, and **Bronze Medal** to their top three favorites (in 3 to 4 player games, only Gold and Silver are awarded). Audience members cast a single vote. Medals convert into weighted shares of the final point pool.

C. *Quiplash 3*: *Thriplash*

Quiplash 3 scrapped the all-play *Last Lash* in favor of returning to **1-v-1 head-to-head battles** called **Thriplash**:

- **How It Works:** Players are paired up 1-v-1 and given a single prompt that requires **three separate short answers** (entered into three distinct text boxes).
    - *Example Prompt:* `"Three things you can say to defuse a tense hostage situation"` or `"Three horrifying phrases to see embroidered on Grandma's pillow"`.
- **Odd-Numbered Player Rule (Fighting Schmitty):** Because *Thriplash* is strictly 1-v-1, if there is an odd number of players (3, 5, or 7 players), the player currently in **last place** at the end of Round 2 is paired against **Schmitty himself**, who submits a pre-written 3-part response (even on user-created custom prompts!).
- **Scoring:** Base pool is **3,000 points**, scaling up to a maximum of **6,000 points** for a 100% sweep—meaning even a player in dead last can mathematically vault into first place with a single *Thriplash* sweep.

5. Complete Edition & Release History (2015–2026)

Title / Release	Release Date	Included In / Format	Key Additions & Differences
Quiplash (Standalone)	June 30, 2015	Standalone (PC, Console, Mobile)	First Jackbox game to introduce Audience (up to 10,000), Family-Friendly Filter, and Extended Timers. Optional paid DLC: *Quip Pack 1* (Sept 15, 2015).
Quiplash XL	Oct 13, 2015	*The Jackbox Party Pack 2*	Includes all base prompts + *Quip Pack 1* + 100 brand-new prompts and extra "Worst Answer" post-game awards.
Quiplash 2	Oct 18, 2016	*The Jackbox Party Pack 3*	Added **Custom Episodes** (user-generated prompt lists), **Safety Quips**, new *Last Lash* modes (*Acro/Word/Comic Lash*), and VIP censorship controls.
Quiplash 2 InterLASHional	Feb 2020	Standalone (Steam, Consoles)	Localized into English, French, Italian, German, and Castilian Spanish with localized voice

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			actors (e.g., Jerry in Italian, Gutierréz in Spanish) and 100 country-specific prompts per language.
Quiplash 3	Oct 15, 2020	*The Jackbox Party Pack 7*	Overhauled 3D claymation art style, introduced **Thriplash** final round, context-aware Safety Quips, live browser Moderation screen, and automated profanity/hate-speech filtering.
The Jackbox Party Starter	June 30, 2022	Standalone 3-Game Bundle	Bundles an updated version of *Quiplash 3* alongside *Tee K.O.* and *Trivia Murder Party 2* with full multi-language localization.
The Jackbox Party Essentials	April 2026	Netflix Games (Smart TVs)	Bundles *Quiplash 3*, *Fibbage 4*, and *Drawful 2* natively inside the Netflix TV app with instant QR-code phone pairing.

6. Prompt Examples & "Quip Pro Quo" (Secret Schmitty Triggers)

Across every version of *Quiplash*, the writers hardcoded hundreds of secret **trigger answers**. If a player submits a specific predictable, clever, or meta response to a certain prompt, Schmitty interrupts the game before voting begins to deliver a custom, fully voiced roast or comment. Triggering one unlocks the "Quip Pro Quo" (or "Back Talk") achievement.

Authentic Prompts & Secret Schmitty Responses

Official Game Prompt	Secret Trigger Answer(s)	Schmitty's Custom Voiced Response
"What a lazy cowboy names his horse"	`Horse`	*"Coincidentally, 'Horse' is what a lazy Quiplash player would type."*
"An odd sequel to the children's book, The Giving Tree"	`The Taking Tree`	*"Personally, I like a tree that takes what he wants. There's*

Official Game Prompt	Secret Trigger Answer(s)	Schmitty's Custom Voiced Response
		nothing more attractive than confidence. I'm sorry, what were we talking about?"
"The name of a singles bar for pirates"	`Booty Bar`	*"Booty Bar? Huh, looks like you just parroted the most common answer to this prompt! Get it? Parroted? [Buzzer sounds] Oops. I just parroted the most common response to your response."*
"The only way out of Mississippi is to _____"	`Die`	*"Actually, if you die in Mississippi, you're both dead, AND in Mississippi."*
"What should be dumped on the losing coach at the end of a football game"	`Urine` / `Pee`	*"Hey, football's not a watersport."*
"Forget hamster balls, modern hamsters get around in hamster _____"	`Hoverboards` / `Hover balls`	*"Yep, and with all that hovering, they don't even get any exercise! This is the Hamster Segway all over again."*
"How do you seduce a bear?"	`Carefully`	*"A careful seduction. Reminds me of the books my mom used to keep by the bathtub."*
"The name of a disease that makes you look like a Minion"	`Miniongitis`	*"Miniongitis, yes. Sadly, miniongitis is incurable. You should always seek out a second op-minion."*
Various prompts asking for "the worst thing" or "something boring"	`Quiplash`	Schmitty sarcastically roasts you (or agrees with you) for insulting the game you are currently playing.

Other Hidden Easter Eggs & Cameos

- **Specific Achievement Words ("Pork Pants" & "Meatloaf Candy"):**
    - In *Quiplash 1 / XL*, winning any head-to-head matchup by typing the exact phrase `"pork pants"` unlocks the **Pork Pants** achievement.
    - In *Quiplash 2*, winning a matchup with the exact phrase `"meatloaf candy"` unlocks the **Meatloaf Candy** achievement.
- **The Instant Game-Over Rage Quit:**
    - In any version of *Quiplash*, if **every single player** fails to enter any answers during a round (leaving all prompts blank) or if 100% of submitted answers are censored by moderation, Schmitty refuses to continue, scolds the room for wasting his time, and **immediately terminates the game to the credits**.
- **The *Trivia Murder Party 2* Crossover:**
    - In *Trivia Murder Party 2* (*Party Pack 6*), one of the 2-player Killing Floor survival minigames is a literal round of *Quiplash* hosted by Schmitty—whose voice lines reveal he was kidnapped and locked in the Murder Hotel basement by the killer host. The player who receives fewer votes from the room is immediately executed.

7. Custom Episodes, Moderation & Streamer Features

Starting in *Quiplash 2* and expanded in *Quiplash 3*, the game includes a full suite of customization and safety controls tailored for both family game nights and public Twitch/YouTube streams:

1. **Custom Episodes (`Make My Own`):**
    - From the main menu, players can launch the Custom Episode creator on their device to write their own list of prompts for inside jokes, bachelor parties, office events, or classroom trivia.
    - Once saved, the server generates a **7-character shareable Episode Code** (e.g., `ABC-DEFG`) that anyone in the world can enter into their copy of *Quiplash 2* or *Quiplash 3* to load that exact prompt deck.
2. **Content & Accessibility Toggles:**
    - **Family-Friendly Filter:** Strips out all suggestive/NSFW official prompts from the deck.
    - **US-Centric Filter:** Removes prompts referencing American-specific pop culture, regional chains, or US politics for international groups.
    - **Profanity & Hate-Speech Filter (*Quiplash 3*):** Automatically blocks slurs and explicit words at the input level before they even reach the screen.
    - **Live Moderation Portal (*Quiplash 3*):** Allows a designated moderator to log in via `jackbox.tv` on a separate device and inspect/veto every player submission in real time before it displays on the main screen.